

Defence conundrum

IT's **intriguing** that India continues to be the world's biggest **arms** importer despite the Modi government's **consistent emphasis** on self-reliance (Atmanirbharta) and **indigenous** production in the defence sector. In his **address** at the ongoing Aero India 2025 in Bengaluru, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said the evolving global security **scenario** demanded innovative approaches and stronger partnerships. But is greater strategic collaboration helping India become a global **powerhouse** of defence research, development and innovation? Or is it making the country more dependent on foreign manufacturers? These questions need to be **addressed** with an open mind by the Centre as well as the **top brass** of the defence forces.

The government's **resolve** to **cut down on** arms imports and boost exports **is** being put to the test by US President Donald Trump. He is **insistent** that India should buy more US-made security equipment. **Trump**, who is **set to host** Prime Minister Modi, **wants** a 'fair' trading relationship with New Delhi. And he has **made no bones** about his **zealousness** to introduce new tariffs on steel and aluminium imports into the US, a move that could hit many Indian companies. **India**, which is **keen on** co-production of Stryker **combat** vehicles and fighter jet engines, **needs** to ensure that such deals are not **skewed** in favour of the US.



Russia's **preoccupation** with the Ukraine war **has prompted** India to rely less on its traditional defence partner and focus more on **acquisitions** from Western nations **in a bid to** diversify supplies. Transfer of technology is a **prerequisite** for **bolstering** domestic production **in the long run**, but some Western firms have shown **reluctance on this count**. The Defence Minister has **asserted** that India does not believe in transactional relationships or **imposing** solutions. However, the same cannot be said with confidence about the country's top partners. New Delhi must **judiciously** prioritise its strategic interests, **striking a balance** between indigenous capacity-building and its 'Make for the world' aspirations.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

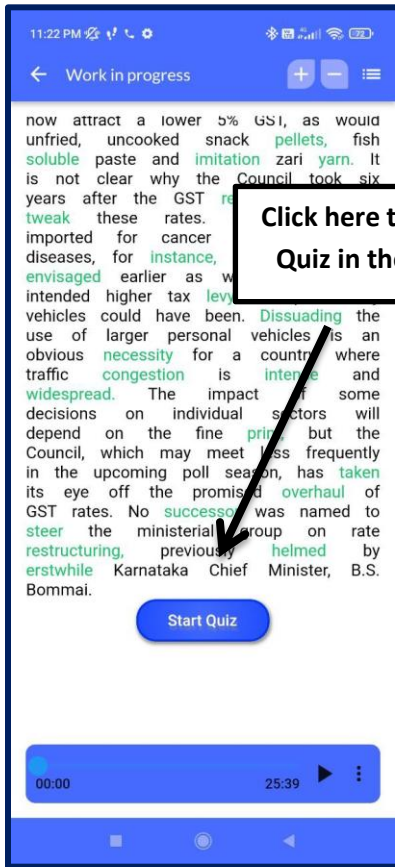
1. **Conundrum** (noun) – Puzzle, Dilemma, Riddle, Problem, Quandary पहेली
2. **Intriguing** (adjective) – Fascinating, Interesting, Captivating, Engaging, Compelling दिलचस्प
3. **Arms** (noun) – Weapons, Ammunition, Firearms, Armaments, Ordnance हथियार
4. **Consistent** (adjective) – Steady, Regular, Uniform, Constant, Persistent सुसंगत
5. **Emphasis** (noun) – Focus, Stress, Importance, Priority, Attention जोर
6. **Indigenous** (adjective) – Native, Local, Domestic, Homegrown, Aboriginal स्वदेशी
7. **Address** (noun) – Speech, Talk, Lecture, Discourse, Presentation भाषण
8. **Scenario** (noun) – Situation, Context, Setting, Circumstance, Background परिदृश्य
9. **Powerhouse** (noun) – Leader, Giant, Force, Hub, Center शक्तिशाली केंद्र
10. **Address** (verb) – Tackle, Handle, Resolve, Confront, Manage सुलझाना
11. **Top brass** (noun) – Leaders, Executives, Authorities, Officials, Higher-ups प्रमुख अधिकारी
12. **Resolve** (noun) – Determination, Decision, Commitment, Resolution, Willpower दृढ़ संकल्प
13. **Cut down on** (phrasal verb) – Definition: To reduce or decrease something. कम करना
14. **Insistent** (adjective) – Persistent, Determined, Adamant, Unyielding, Forceful जिद्दी
15. **Set** (to) (adjective) – Ready, Prepared, Scheduled, Arranged, Fixed तैयार
16. **Host** (verb) – Welcome, Entertain, Receive, Accommodate, Greet मेज़बानी करना
17. **Make no bones** (phrase) – Definition: To be straightforward or frank about something. स्पष्ट रूप से कहना
18. **Zealousness** (noun) – Enthusiasm, Passion, Eagerness, Fervor, Ardor उत्साह
19. **Keen** (on) (adjective) – Eager, Enthusiastic, Interested, Willing, Desirous उत्सुक
20. **Combat** (verb) – Fight, Battle, Confront, Oppose, Resist लड़ना
21. **Skew** (verb) – Distort, Bias, Twist, Slant, Misrepresent झुका हुआ होना
22. **Preoccupation** (noun) – Obsession, Concern, Fixation, Engagement, Distraction पूर्वव्यस्तता

23. **Prompt** (verb) – Encourage, Stimulate, Provoke, Trigger, Induce प्रेरित करना
24. **Acquisition** (noun) – Procurement, Purchase, Gain, Obtainment, Addition अधिग्रहण
25. **In a bid to** (phrase) – Definition: In an attempt to achieve something. के प्रयास में
26. **Prerequisite** (noun) – Requirement, Condition, Necessity, Essential, Precondition पूर्वापेक्षा
27. **Bolster** (verb) – Strengthen, Support, Reinforce, Boost, Enhance मजबूत करना
28. **In the long run** (phrase) – Definition: Over a long period of time; eventually. लंबे समय में
29. **Reluctance** (noun) – Hesitation, Unwillingness, Resistance, Disinclination, Doubt अनिच्छा
30. **On this count** (phrase) – Definition: In this regard or aspect. इस मामले में
31. **Assert** (verb) – Declare, Affirm, State, Insist, Maintain दृढ़ता से कहना
32. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, Levy, Apply, Inflict, Introduce थोपना
33. **Judiciously** (adverb) – Wisely, Sensibly, Prudently, Carefully, Thoughtfully विवेकपूर्ण ढंग से
34. **Strike a balance** (phrase) – Definition: To achieve a fair or reasonable compromise. संतुलन बनाना

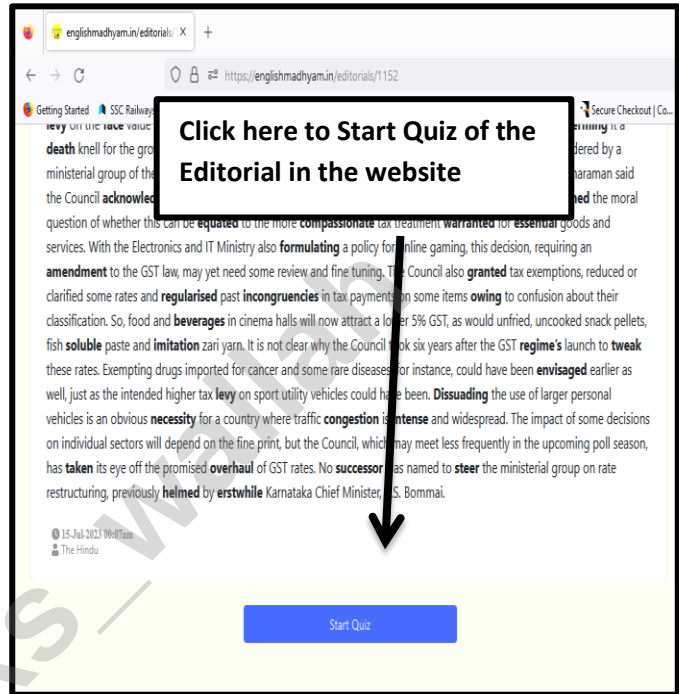
Summary of the Editorial

1. **India's Arms Imports:** Despite the Modi government's push for self-reliance (Atmanirbharta), India remains the world's largest arms importer.
2. **Aero India 2025:** Defence Minister Rajnath Singh emphasized the need for innovative approaches and stronger partnerships in the evolving global security scenario.
3. **Self-Reliance vs. Dependency:** Questions arise whether strategic collaborations are fostering indigenous defence innovation or increasing dependency on foreign manufacturers.
4. **US Pressure:** US President Donald Trump is pressuring India to buy more US-made security equipment, seeking a 'fair' trading relationship.
5. **Tariff Threats:** Trump's proposed tariffs on steel and aluminium imports could adversely impact Indian companies.
6. **Co-Production Deals:** India aims for co-production of Stryker combat vehicles and fighter jet engines but must ensure these deals are balanced and not skewed in favour of the US.
7. **Shift from Russia:** Russia's focus on the Ukraine war has led India to diversify its defence acquisitions, relying more on Western nations.
8. **Technology Transfer:** Transfer of technology is crucial for India's long-term domestic production, but some Western firms have been reluctant to share advanced technologies.
9. **Transactional Relationships:** India asserts it does not engage in transactional relationships, but its partners may not share the same approach.
10. **Strategic Prioritization:** India must carefully balance its strategic interests, focusing on indigenous capacity-building while pursuing its 'Make for the world' vision.
11. **Defence Exports:** The government's goal to reduce imports and boost defence exports faces challenges due to global geopolitical dynamics.
12. **Global Partnerships:** While partnerships are essential, India must ensure they align with its long-term defence and economic goals.
13. **Domestic Innovation:** Strengthening domestic research, development, and innovation is key to reducing reliance on foreign arms imports.
14. **Policy Clarity:** The Centre and defence forces need to address these issues with an open mind and clear policies to achieve self-reliance.
15. **Balanced Approach:** India must strike a balance between leveraging global partnerships and fostering indigenous defence capabilities to secure its strategic interests.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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